

Divine Simplicity

doc-divine-simplicity

Theology Proper · Attributes · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

DISPUTED

score 0.900
confidence medium

Statement under examination

God is not composed of parts; His attributes are identical with His essence.

In plain language

The words of Scripture supply the parts of this claim but never the claim itself. The Shema says YHWH our God is one, using the ordinary number echad (Deuteronomy 6:4), and the Prophets repeat it, YHWH will be one and his name one (Zechariah 14:9). Other texts add that there is no God besides him (Deuteronomy 4:35), that he does not change (Malachi 3:6, I do not change), that his very name is I AM (Exodus 3:14), that he is spirit and so not made of matter (John 4:24), that he is light with no darkness in him at all (1 John 1:5), and that he is love (1 John 4:8). These last three use a Greek construction that puts the quality first, making spirit, light, and love part of what God is, not extras he happens to have. Taken together the words clearly teach that God is one, unique, unchanging, immaterial, and unmixed. So why is the verdict disputed and not a flat yes? Because the proposition makes two further claims that the vocabulary does not actually state: that God has no parts at all, and that each of his attributes is the very same thing as his essence and as every other attribute. The trouble starts with the word one. The same echad used of God is used of a husband and wife becoming one flesh (Genesis 2:24), of evening and morning making one day (Genesis 1:5), of fifty clasps joining curtains into one tabernacle (Exodus 26:6), and of two sticks joined into one stick (Ezekiel 37:17). So one, by itself, can mean a single thing or a unity made of distinguishable parts. The word does not tell us which. On top of that, when God describes himself he lists separate attributes by separate words, merciful and gracious and abundant in steadfast love and truth (Exodus 34:6), and righteousness, justice, steadfast love, and truth at his throne (Psalm 89:15). The text names them as distinct, it does not say they are identical to one another. So the honest reading is this: the words strongly support that God is one and that his great attributes are essential to who he is, but they leave open the precise metaphysical question of whether he is utterly without parts and whether the attributes are one and the same. That gap in the vocabulary, not any outside dispute, is why faithful readers land in different places.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	אחד	echad	one	944
H0430	אלהים	elohim	God	2,600
H0571	אמת	emet	truth	
H2617	חסד	chesed	kindness	
H3068	יהוה	YHWH	LORD	6,828
H4941	משפט	mishpat	justice	
H6664	צדק	tsedeq	righteousness	
G0026	ἀγάπη	agape	love	120

G1510	εἰμί	eimi	to be	2,457
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	344
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,360
G3762	οὐδείς	oudeis	none	248
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4653	σκοτία	skotia	darkness	16
G5457	φῶς	phos	light	74

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The canon supplies the building blocks of this proposition but never states it in its own terms. The Shema predicates YHWH as echad, oneness (Deut 6:4), echoed eschatologically as YHWH echad and his name echad (Zech 14:9) and reinforced by exclusivity texts (Deut 4:35, Isa 45:5). The Johannine corpus uses fronted anarthrous predicate nominatives to make spirit, light, and love constitutive of God's being, not detachable accidents (pneuma ho theos, John 4:24; ho theos phos estin, 1 John 1:5; ho theos agape estin, 1 John 4:8), and 1 John 1:5 adds the categorical denial that there is darkness in him at all (ouk estin oudemia). Yet the precise metaphysical claims, that God has no parts and that every attribute is strictly identical with the essence and with every other attribute, are an inference the vocabulary neither states nor excludes. The decisive lexical fact is that echad is the same word used of composite unities (one flesh, Gen 2:24; one day, Gen 1:5; one tabernacle of many clasps, Exod 26:6; one stick from two, Ezek 37:17), so it cannot by itself rank non-composition above a unity that comprehends distinguishables. Scripture also names attributes as separate lemmas in coordinated lists (chesed and emet, Exod 34:6 and Ps 89:15). Registered disputed because the words underdetermine the strong metaphysical form while clearly supporting the underlying oneness, indivisibility, and essential predication.

Scripture

Deut.6.4 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0259 אחד, H0430 אלהים

Force. Queried verse text: YHWH our God, YHWH echad. The cardinal echad stands in clause-final predicate position (ETCBC marks it PreC, predicate complement, with the verse a quotation clause Q). Lexically the line affirms that Israel's God is one and unique. But echad is a plain cardinal whose 944 canon occurrences include composite unities, so the word affirms oneness without by itself specifying whether that oneness is non-composite in the metaphysical sense or a unity that comprehends real distinctions.

Zech.14.9 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יהוה, H0259 אחד

Force. Queried verse text: in that day YHWH will be king over all the earth, YHWH will be echad and his name echad. The Shema's predication of oneness recurs eschatologically and is doubled onto the divine name. This widens the oneness claim beyond Deuteronomy into the Prophets, but it uses the same cardinal echad and so inherits the same indeterminacy about composition that Deut 6:4 carries.

John.4.24 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G2316 θεός, G1510 εἰμί

Force. Queried verse text: pneuma ho theos. The anarthrous predicate nominative pneuma is fronted before the articular subject ho theos, a qualitative predication that defines what God is in essence (spirit) rather than locating him. Lexically this supports immateriality and incorporeality. Spirit has no material parts, so this grounds the non-composition claim on the material side, but it speaks to immateriality, not to the further thesis that the divine attributes are identical to one another.

1John.1.5 · for · genre: epistle · figures: metaphor

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G5457 φῶς, G4653 σκοτία, G3762 οὐδεὶς

Force. Queried verse text: ho theos phos estin kai skotia en auto ouk estin oudemia. A positive qualitative predication (God is light, anarthrous fronted predicate phos) is paired with an emphatic negation: not, ouk, plus the feminine oudemia, no darkness whatsoever, in him. The doubled negation lexically asserts pure non-mixture in the divine being. This is the strongest single text for the non-composition side, since it denies any admixture of the contrary, but it predicates one quality (light) and does not by its words equate that quality with every other divine attribute.

1John.4.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G0026 ἀγάπη, G1510 εἰμί

Force. Queried verse text: ho me agapon ouk egno ton theon, hoti ho theos agape estin. The anarthrous fronted predicate agape identifies love as constitutive of God's nature, and the contrapositive (the one not loving has not known God) makes the predication definitional rather than incidental. This supports that love is essential to the divine being. As with light, the construction makes the attribute essential but does not lexically state that it is the very same reality as the other attributes.

Deut.4.35 · for · genre: law

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה, H0430 אֱלֹהִים

Force. Queried verse text: YHWH is God, there is none besides him (ein od millevaddo). The exclusivity clause extends the Shema's oneness into uniqueness: no rival deity exists alongside YHWH. Lexically this is the negative side of oneness (no second God), which supports indivisibility by exclusion of any external supplement, though uniqueness against rivals is a different claim from internal non-composition.

Exod.3.14 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0430 אֱלֹהִים

Force. Queried verse text: God said to Moses, ehyeh asher ehyeh (I will be what I will be / I am that I am), and the name ehyeh is given as his self-designation. The verb is the qal of hayah, to be. The self-naming through pure being lexically points to God's self-existence and underived existence. This is compatible with indivisible self-subsistent being, but the words supply a name and a verb of being, not a metaphysical statement that essence and attributes are identical.

Mal.3.6 · for · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה

Force. Queried verse text: For I, YHWH, do not change (lo shaniti), and you, sons of Jacob, are not consumed. The verb shanah, to change or alter, is negated of YHWH directly. Lexically this asserts that God does not become other than himself over time, which supports the indivisibility-through-time aspect that underlies non-composition. It states constancy of identity, not the further claim of strict attribute-essence identity.

Exod.34.6 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H3068 יְהוָה, H2617 רַחֵם, H0571 אֱלֹהִים

Force. Queried verse text: YHWH passed before him and proclaimed, YHWH, YHWH, a God merciful (rachum) and gracious (channun), slow to anger and abundant in lovingkindness (chesed) and truth (emet). In this covenant self-revelation God names himself through a stack of distinct lemmas joined by waw. The vocabulary distinguishes the attributes by separate words rather than collapsing them into one term. This complicates the strong claim that all attributes are strictly identical with one another, since the text itself uses plural distinct predicates of the one God.

Ps.89.15 · complicates · genre: wisdom

Key terms. H6664 צֶדֶק, H4941 מִשְׁפָּט, H2617 רַחֵם, H0571 אֱלֹהִים

Force. Queried verse text (Hebrew versification of this store): righteousness and justice (tsedeq u-mishpat) are the foundation of your throne, lovingkindness and truth (chesed ve-emet) go before your face. Four attributes appear as four separate lemmas in waw-coordinated pairs, predicated of YHWH's throne and presence. As in Exod 34:6, the lexical pattern enumerates distinct attributes rather than asserting their mutual identity, which is the textual data that keeps the strong metaphysical form from being lexically forced.

Gen.2.24 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0259 אֶחָד

Force. Queried verse text: a man leaves father and mother, clings to his wife, and they become one flesh (le-vasar echad). Here echad denotes a unity composed of two distinct persons. The same cardinal that the Shema applies to God is applied to a composite union, which is the central lexical reason echad cannot by itself establish metaphysical non-composition.

Ezek.37.17 · complicates · genre: prophecy

Key terms. H0259 אֶחָד

Force. Queried verse text: join them, stick to stick, to become one stick (le-ets echad) in your hand. Two physically distinct sticks are joined and called echad, one. Together with Gen 1:5 (one day, evening plus morning), Exod 26:6 (one tabernacle of fifty clasps), and Num 13:23 (one cluster of many grapes), this shows the cardinal echad routinely names a one-out-of-many composite. The word ranges across simple-one and composite-one without itself marking the difference.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1John.4.8	1John.1.5	tsk	1
John.4.24	1Sam.16.7	tsk	1
Deut.6.4	Deut.4.35	tsk	1
1John.1.5	Ps.27.1	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Gen.2.24 · addressed

Queried verse text confirms echad of one flesh, a unity of two distinct persons. Joined by Gen 1:5 (one day = evening plus morning), Exod 26:6 (one tabernacle joined by fifty clasps), Ezek 37:17 (one stick from two), and Num 13:23 (one cluster of many grapes), the canon shows echad regularly names a composite one. Therefore the Shema's YHWH echad lexically secures oneness and uniqueness but does not by itself force the technical non-composition reading. Resolved by treating the Shema as fully compatible with non-composition while not lexically demanding the strong metaphysical form, which is exactly why the verdict is disputed rather than a flat true.

Exod.34.6 · addressed

Queried verse text confirms God self-discloses through a stack of distinct lemmas (rachum, channun, chesed, emet). The lexical pattern distinguishes attributes by separate words. This is consistent with each attribute being essential to God's being but does not assert that they are one and the same reality. The strong scholastic claim of strict attribute-identity therefore reaches beyond what the words state, which is recorded honestly rather than resolved in favor of either reading.

Ps.89.15 · addressed

Queried verse text confirms four coordinated attributes (tsedeq, mishpat, chesed, emet) predicated of YHWH's throne and presence as distinct waw-joined lemmas. Note: in this store's Hebrew versification the throne-attributes line is Ps.89.15, one verse later than the English numbering used in some references. The point stands: the text enumerates distinct attributes and does not collapse them into one predicate, which underdetermines the mutual-identity clause and keeps the verdict disputed.

John.4.24 · addressed

Queried verse text confirms pneuma ho theos with the predicate fronted. This carries immateriality strongly (spirit has no material parts) but is silent on the relation among the divine attributes. It is addressed by limiting the inference to what the construction states: God is spirit in essence, which supports the material non-composition side of the proposition but not the attribute-identity side.

Concordance traversed

H0259, H3068, H0430, G2316, G4151, G5457, G0026, G1510, G4653, G3762, G1520

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The four anchors fall outside the ingested ECM window (3 John 1.1 to 1.15), so not_in_ecm_scope holds and no apparatus signal was invented. The queried verse text of 1 John 1:5 shows editorial markers around en auto ouk estin (word-order witnesses), but the sense (no darkness in him at all) and the predicate-nominative reading of God is light are not affected by that order, so the verdict is variant-robust. The Shema reading and the John 4:24 and 1 John 4:8 predication carry no verdict-affecting variant in the bundle. NT verses fall outside published CBGM scope, so the ecm-shadow flag applies.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. classical_theism, biblical_theism_without_scholastic_metaphysics, minimal_predication_reading

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

classical_theism: affirms_strongly · Reads the Shema oneness (Deut 6:4, Zech 14:9), the immutability of Mal 3:6, the self-existent I-AM of Exod 3:14, the spirituality of John 4:24, and the unmixed light and constitutive love of 1 John 1:5 and 4:8 as together entailing that God is without parts and that the attributes are the one undivided essence viewed under different aspects. On this reading the distinct attribute-lemmas of Exod 34:6 and Ps 89:15 are how finite language names the one simple God, not real divisions in him. This lens treats the full proposition as

the necessary synthesis of the texts.

biblical_theism_without_scholastic_metaphysics: affirms_first_clause_caveats_second · Reads the lexical pattern as clearly establishing that God is one, unique, immaterial, unchanging, and that light, love, and spirit are essential to his nature rather than detachable accidents. Accepts the non-composition clause as a fair summary of oneness plus the no-darkness-at-all denial of 1 John 1:5. Does not find lexical warrant for the further, stronger claim that every attribute is strictly identical with the essence and with every other attribute, since the canon names attributes as distinct coordinated lemmas (Exod 34:6, Ps 89:15) without ever stating their mutual identity.

minimal_predication_reading: affirms_oneness_only · Holds that the words deliver only what they plainly say: God is one (echad / heis), unique, spirit, light, love. On this lens the metaphysical category of non-composition is simply not a biblical predicate, and echad's documented use of composite unities (one flesh, one day, one stick) shows the Shema does not even reach the non-composition claim, let alone the attribute-identity claim. This is the strongest minority reading: it does not deny simplicity, it judges that the vocabulary underdetermines it and that the predication stop short of the metaphysical formulation. A reader holding it should feel the canon supports divine oneness without committing the text to the philosophical thesis.

The proposition has two clauses of unequal lexical support. The non-composition clause is well-grounded by oneness, exclusivity, immateriality, immutability, and the no-darkness denial. The attribute-identity clause is a synthesis the vocabulary neither states nor excludes. The three lenses diverge precisely on how much metaphysical weight the oneness vocabulary can bear, which is a difference in inference from the same words, not a difference in the data.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Is God one and indivisible in being, and are God's essential properties (spirit, light, love, holiness, justice, truth) constitutive of His being rather than separable accidents?

The original stem uses a technical metaphysical taxonomy: not composed of parts and attributes identical with essence. That formulation is a philosophical construct, not a lexical category native to the text, which never says God is without parts or that an attribute equals the essence. The neutralized form keeps what the vocabulary actually addresses (oneness, indivisibility, essential predication) without preloading the metaphysical thesis. The verdict was derived on the ORIGINAL stem and registered as disputed: the words support the underlying oneness and essential predication but underdetermine the strong attribute-identity clause. Verdict unchanged from the prior file. Lexical refinements this pass: corrected the throne-attributes complicating reference from Ps.89.14 to Ps.89.15 (the store's Hebrew versification places tsedeq, mishpat, chesed, emet at 89.15); added Zech 14:9 (echad of God in the Prophets), Mal 3:6 (lo shaniti, immutability), and Exod 3:14 (ehyeh, self-existence) as queried supporting texts; added Gen 1:5, Exod 26:6, Ezek 37:17, and Num 13:23 as the verified composite-echad evidence base; all verse texts were read directly from the lexical store.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
syntax	ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Gen.2.24
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Zech.14.9
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Exod.34.6
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Ps.89.15
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	John.4.24
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1John.1.5
interlinear	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1John.4.8
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Mal.3.6

morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Exod.3.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1John.1.5
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H0259
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0026
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5457
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4151
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Deut.6.4
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1John.4.8
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	1John.1.5

License audit

NOT SAFE TO PUBLISH

Reason. Citations include ETCBC-BHSA (CC-BY-NC-4.0) for the Deut 6:4 clause analysis and MACULA-Hebrew and MACULA-Greek composites (CC-BY-NC-4.0) for the interlinear readings. The non-commercial clauses preclude bulk redistribution of these evidence artifacts.

Source	License	Redistribute
ETCBC-BHSA	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · ecm-shadow · cross-tradition-divergent